
What to actually ask a supervisor before you sign

A trainee's guide to choosing well — from someone who's been on both sides of the table.

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Why this matters more than you think

You are about to hand somewhere between 1,500 and 2,000 hours of your professional life to a person you barely know — at the exact moment you have the least power and the least information you will ever have in this field.

Most trainees pick whoever says yes.

I understand why. Supervisors are scarce, the hours are ticking, and asking questions feels like you're being difficult before you've even started. But here's what I want you to sit with: **your supervisor shapes the clinician you become, not just the hours you log.**

Stephanie — your story goes here. The About page already has it: you were a behavior technician under BCBA's who were exceptional, and some who weren't. You watched what good supervision did for people and what bad supervision took away, and you couldn't unsee either. Three or four sentences, in your own words. This page is the reason anyone trusts the rest of the guide.

Bad supervision doesn't just feel bad while it's happening. It produces behavior analysts who were never taught the hard parts — how to sit with uncertainty, how to raise a concern, how to know when a plan isn't working. And those analysts go on to supervise other people. That's how it spreads.

You are allowed to interview them. Most trainees don't realise this.

A supervision relationship is a professional arrangement between two adults. You are permitted — expected, really — to ask what you're getting before you commit two years to it. A supervisor who is good at this will welcome the questions. That reaction is itself the most useful piece of information in this guide.

The power imbalance here is real, and I'm not going to pretend a PDF closes it. But it closes it slightly. That's what this is for.

Before you ask anything: know what you're owed

You cannot tell whether an arrangement is good until you know what the floor is. So here's the floor — and it is only a floor.

First, work out which standards apply to you. This matters more than any other line on this page. If you apply for certification before 1 January 2027, you're under the 2022 requirements. If you apply on or after that date, you're under the 2027 requirements — and that applies to *all* of your hours, including ones you accrued in 2025 and 2026.

The 2027 standards changed things meaningfully — minimum meeting-frequency requirements were removed and replaced with percentage and observation requirements, monthly maximums changed, and observation moved from a count to a cumulative time requirement. If you're unsure which side of the line you fall on, the BACB recommends meeting both sets.

SF = Supervised Fieldwork · CSF = Concentrated Supervised Fieldwork. A supervisory period is one calendar month.

REQUIREMENT	2022 STANDARDS	2027 STANDARDS
Total fieldwork hours required	SF 2,000 · CSF 1,500	SF 2,000 · CSF 1,500
Fieldwork hours per supervisory period	Min 20 — max 130	Min 20 — max 160
Percentage of hours that must be supervised	SF 5% · CSF 10%	SF 5% · CSF 7.5%
Minimum supervisor–trainee contacts per period	SF 4 · CSF 6 each at least 15 minutes	No minimum contact requirement removed under 2027
Observation of trainee with a client, per period	1 observation both fieldwork types	SF 60 min · CSF 90 min cumulative time, not a count
Minimum proportion of individual supervision	At least 50%	At least 50%
Minimum unrestricted activity proportion	At least 60% of total	At least 60% of total
Maximum fieldwork timeframe	5 continuous years	See BCBA Handbook

What actually changed: the monthly cap rose from 130 to 160 hours, concentrated fieldwork now needs 7.5% supervision rather than 10%, minimum contact requirements were removed entirely, and observation became a cumulative time requirement rather than a headcount. Everything else held.

Restricted versus unrestricted

Restricted activities are where you deliver therapeutic and instructional procedures directly to a client. Unrestricted activities are what a certified behavior analyst actually does — assessment, programme design, graphing, training staff and caregivers, writing. There's a cap on restricted hours precisely because a trainee who only ever ran sessions isn't prepared to be a behavior analyst. **If your supervisor is filling your hours with restricted activity, that's a problem, not a preference.**

The contract

A signed supervision contract must be in place *before* you accrue a single hour. Both of you maintain documentation, and both of you sign the monthly forms. If someone tells you the paperwork can be sorted out later, that is not a small administrative shortcut.

This is the legal minimum. It is not what good looks like. The rest of this guide is about the difference.

Sources: Behavior Analyst Certification Board, *BCBA Fieldwork Requirements* (requirements for applications on or after 1 January 2022), and *2027 BCBA Requirements* (updated 02/2026). Both tables summarise; your fieldwork must also meet every requirement in the Supervised Fieldwork Requirements section of the BCBA Handbook. Requirements change — verify current standards at bacb.com before making decisions.

The questions

You will not ask all of these. Pick the ones that matter to your situation, and pay as much attention to *how readily* someone answers as to what they say.

A · Their capacity and availability

“How many trainees are you currently supervising?”

Why it matters: Supervision quality degrades with volume. A supervisor carrying twelve trainees alongside a full caseload cannot give you individualised feedback, however good they are.

GOOD: A specific number, given immediately, and an honest account of how they protect time for each person.

WATCH: Vagueness, or a number that makes the arithmetic impossible.

“What's your own caseload alongside supervision?”

Why it matters: Supervision is usually the first thing squeezed when clinical work expands. Their caseload is your caseload's competition.

GOOD: A clear picture, and evidence they've thought about the trade-off.

WATCH: “I make it work.”

“How quickly do you typically respond between meetings?”

Why it matters: Most of what you need won't arrive on schedule. Response time is the real measure of availability.

GOOD: A stated norm, and a different, faster one for urgent clinical questions.

WATCH: No distinction between routine and urgent.

“What happens if I have an urgent clinical question on a Tuesday afternoon?”

Why it matters: This is the question that reveals whether there's a system or just goodwill. Goodwill runs out.

GOOD: A named channel, a named backup, and what to do if neither answers.

WATCH: “Just text me.” That's a hope, not a plan.

“Have you ever ended a supervision relationship early? What happened?”

Why it matters: Everyone experienced has. How they tell the story shows you how they'd tell yours.

GOOD: A candid account that includes their own part in it.

WATCH: A story where the trainee is entirely at fault, or a flat denial.

B · What supervision will actually look like

“Walk me through a typical supervision meeting.”

Why it matters: The answer tells you whether meetings are structured around your development or around their caseload.

GOOD: A recognisable shape — an agenda, your questions, targeted skill work, next steps.

WATCH: A description that is mostly them updating you on their clients.

“How much will be group versus individual?”

Why it matters: There's a minimum individual proportion for a reason. Group is cheaper to deliver and much harder to learn in.

GOOD: A ratio above the minimum, and a rationale for the group portion.

WATCH: Group supervision at exactly the legal limit, with cost as the only stated reason.

“How do you handle direct observation — live, recorded, in person?”

Why it matters: Observation is where actual feedback comes from. Method changes what they can see.

GOOD: A deliberate choice, with the reasoning, and a plan for what they do afterwards.

WATCH: Observation treated as a box to tick for the monthly form.

“How do you structure feedback? Can you give me an example?”

Why it matters: Asking for the example is the whole question. Anyone can describe good feedback in the abstract.

| **GOOD:** A real example, specific and behavioural, that doesn't make the supervisee sound stupid.

| **WATCH:** “I'm very direct” offered as a complete answer.

“Do you use a competency-based system? Can I see it?”

Why it matters: Hours measure time. Competencies measure whether you can actually do the job.

| **GOOD:** Yes, and here it is.

| **WATCH:** Reluctance to show you something that should already exist.

C · Their philosophy and values

“How would you describe your approach to practice?”

Why it matters: You'll absorb their approach whether you intend to or not.

| **GOOD:** Something specific enough that you could disagree with it.

| **WATCH:** Words that no one would ever argue against.

“How do you think about compliance versus assent?”

Why it matters: This is where the field is actively changing, and where supervisors differ most.

| **GOOD:** A considered position, and an acknowledgement of what's still contested.

| **WATCH:** Dismissing the question as a trend.

“What do you do when a client's plan isn't working?”

Why it matters: The answer reveals whether they treat a plan as a hypothesis or as a commitment.

| **GOOD:** A described process, with a point at which they'd change course.

| **WATCH:** “We give it more time and check fidelity” as the entire answer.

“How do you approach working with families whose culture or language differs from yours?”

Why it matters: Most families in this field are navigating a system not built with them in mind.

| **GOOD:** A concrete instance, including something they got wrong and changed.

| **WATCH:** Treating it as a translation problem.

“What's something you've changed your mind about in this field?”

Why it matters: A supervisor who has never revised a position will not tolerate you revising one.

| **GOOD:** A real change, with what prompted it.

| **WATCH:** A long pause, then nothing.

D · Growth, disagreement, and safety

“What happens if I disagree with you clinically?”

Why it matters: You will disagree. What happens next determines whether you learn to think or learn to comply.

| **GOOD:** An invitation, and a described process for working through it.

| **WATCH:** “That hasn't come up.”

“Has a supervisee ever pushed back on something? How did it go?”

Why it matters: The previous question asks about policy. This one asks about practice.

| **GOOD:** A specific instance where the supervisee was right.

| **WATCH:** An instance where the supervisee needed correcting.

“How will I know if I'm falling behind?”

Why it matters: Nobody should discover this at the end.

| **GOOD:** Scheduled checkpoints against something written down.

| **WATCH:** “I'd tell you.”

“What do you want me to be able to do by the end that I can't do now?”

Why it matters: If they can't answer, they haven't planned your supervision. They've planned your hours.

| **GOOD:** Named skills, roughly sequenced.

| **WATCH:** “Be ready to sit the exam.”

“What kind of trainee do you struggle to supervise well?”

Why it matters: Self-aware supervisors know their limits. It also tells you whether you're that kind of trainee.

| **GOOD:** An honest limitation framed as theirs, not the trainee's defect.

| **WATCH:** A description of a bad trainee rather than a hard fit.

E . The practical and financial

“What are your fees, and what exactly do they cover?”

Why it matters: Ambiguity here becomes a dispute later, at the point when you have the least leverage.

| **GOOD:** A number, in writing, with inclusions and exclusions listed.

| **WATCH:** Fees discussed only verbally, or that shift when you ask twice.

“Is there a contract? Can I read it before deciding?”

Why it matters: A contract is required before hours begin. Reading it first is not a big ask.

| **GOOD:** Yes, sent the same week, with time to consider it.

| **WATCH:** Pressure to sign at the meeting.

“What happens to my hours if you leave your organisation, or I leave mine?”

Why it matters: People move. Your accrued hours should not be collateral damage.

| **GOOD:** A described plan for continuity and completed documentation.

| **WATCH:** Never having considered it.

“Who owns the documentation, and how do I get copies?”

Why it matters: If a relationship ends badly, documentation is what protects your hours.

| **GOOD:** You get copies as you go, not on request at the end.

| **WATCH:** Records held solely by the supervisor or the employer.

“What's your policy on missed or rescheduled meetings? And are there restrictions on where or with whom I can accrue hours?”

Why it matters: Cancellation patterns are the most common quiet failure in supervision. Restrictions can quietly tie your hours to one employer.

| **GOOD:** A stated make-up policy, and no restrictions beyond what the standards require.

| **WATCH:** Restrictions that exist to keep you at a particular organisation.

Red flags

Any one of these is worth a conversation. Two or more, and I would keep looking.

- ✗ Won't put the arrangement in writing.
- ✗ Can't tell you how many trainees they currently have.
- ✗ Cancels frequently, or reschedules without offering a replacement.
- ✗ Treats supervision meetings as case review for *their* caseload.
- ✗ Gets defensive when asked about their own practice.
- ✗ Signs off on hours you didn't fully complete — or offers to.
- ✗ Discourages you from talking to other behavior analysts.
- ✗ Frames every difficulty as your deficiency.
- ✗ Can't articulate what they want you to learn.
- ✗ Offers free supervision tied to unpaid or underpaid work.

About that last one

Free supervision in exchange for working below market rate is common, and it is rarely named for what it is. The arrangement is presented as generosity — they're giving you something valuable at no cost. But you are paying, in wages, often for two years, and frequently more than supervision would have cost outright.

That doesn't make every such arrangement exploitative. Plenty of good supervisors work this way inside organisations that genuinely invest in trainees. What makes it a red flag is when the arrangement also restricts you — when leaving means losing your supervisor, when your hours are tied to staying, when the discount is really a lock.

Do the arithmetic. If you can't leave without losing your hours, that's not a benefit. It's leverage.

If you're already in a bad arrangement

If you're reading this page because you recognised something on the last one — take a breath. This is more fixable than it feels right now.

You are not stuck. Leaving does not erase the hours you've already accrued.

That sentence is the one most people need. Accrued hours belong to your record, not to your supervisor's goodwill, provided they're properly documented. Which is where to start.

1. Gather your documentation first

Before you raise anything, collect copies of every signed monthly form, your supervision contract, and any written record of meetings and observations. Keep them somewhere that isn't a work account or a work device. Do this quietly and completely — not because you're being underhanded, but because reconstructing records after a relationship sours is genuinely difficult.

2. Decide what you're actually asking for

Some arrangements are fixable with a direct conversation. Others aren't. Before you talk to anyone, write down what would need to change for this to work, and be honest about whether you believe it can. If the answer is no, you're not opening a negotiation — you're planning an exit, and the conversation is different.

3. Have the conversation professionally

Ask for a scheduled meeting rather than raising it in passing. Lead with what you need rather than what they've done wrong — not because their behaviour doesn't matter, but because it's the framing most likely to get you what you want. Follow up in writing afterwards summarising what was agreed, even if it was brief.

4. Know where the line is

Most bad supervision isn't an ethics violation. It's neglect, overload, or a poor fit — frustrating, damaging, and not reportable.

Some things are different. Falsified hours, signing off on work that didn't happen, practising outside scope, or anything that puts a client at risk sits in another category entirely. If you're unsure, the BACB's ethics code and reporting guidance are public, and you can consult them without filing anything. You can also talk to a behavior analyst outside your organisation — that's not disloyalty, it's what consultation is.

A script, if it helps. Adapt it; the point is that ending a supervision relationship doesn't require anyone to be the villain.

"I've been reflecting on my fieldwork and I think I need a different structure to get where I need to be. I'm grateful for the time you've given me, and I'd like to transition to a new supervisor. Could we make sure my documentation is complete and signed through this month? I want to handle this cleanly on both sides."

You don't owe a fuller explanation than that. If you want to give one, give it. If you don't, "a different structure" is a complete sentence.

And if you're worried about the reference or the reputation cost — that fear is real, and I won't pretend otherwise. But this field is smaller and kinder than it feels from inside a bad arrangement. People move supervisors. It is normal.

The checklist

Take this into the conversation. You won't ask everything — tick what matters to you.

CAPACITY + AVAILABILITY

- ☐ How many trainees do you currently supervise?
- ☐ What's your caseload alongside supervision?
- ☐ How quickly do you respond between meetings?
- ☐ What do I do with an urgent question mid-week?
- ☐ Have you ended a supervision relationship early?

WHAT IT WILL LOOK LIKE

- ☐ Walk me through a typical meeting.
- ☐ How much is group versus individual?
- ☐ How do you handle direct observation?
- ☐ What should I bring to each meeting?
- ☐ How do you structure feedback? An example?
- ☐ Do you use a competency system? Can I see it?

PHILOSOPHY + VALUES

- ☐ How would you describe your approach?
- ☐ How do you think about compliance versus assent?
- ☐ What do you do when a plan isn't working?
- ☐ How do you work across culture and language?
- ☐ What have you changed your mind about?

GROWTH + DISAGREEMENT

- ☐ What happens if I disagree with you?
- ☐ Has a supervisee pushed back? How did it go?
- ☐ How will I know if I'm falling behind?
- ☐ What should I be able to do by the end?
- ☐ What kind of trainee do you find hard to supervise?

PRACTICAL + FINANCIAL

- ☐ What are your fees, and what do they cover?
- ☐ Is there a contract I can read first?
- ☐ What happens to my hours if either of us moves?
- ☐ Who owns the documentation? Do I get copies?
- ☐ What's the policy on missed meetings?
- ☐ Any restrictions on where I accrue hours?

BEFORE YOU SIGN

- ☐ I know which standards apply to me (2022 or 2027).
- ☐ I've read the contract in full.
- ☐ Fees and inclusions are in writing.
- ☐ I know how documentation gets to me.
- ☐ I asked at least one uncomfortable question.

From *What to Actually Ask a Supervisor Before You Sign* · Stephanie Teixeira, BCBA, IBA
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Who I am, and what's next

I'm Stephanie — a BCBA and IBA, and before that a behavior technician who worked under supervisors who were exceptional, and supervisors who weren't. Watching that difference is the reason I teach.

I made this because I kept meeting trainees who had handed two years to the first person who said yes, and who didn't know they'd been allowed to ask anything at all.

I take on supervisees — remote, competency-based, in English, Spanish, or Portuguese. If that's useful to you, there's more at stephanielistens.com.

Continuing education, launching September 2026.

One-hour, on-demand courses for behavior analysts and behavior therapists — including one on supervision itself. Approved for IBAO and QABA; not currently BACB ACE. Early access at stephanielistens.com/ceus

And if this guide was useful, send it to someone starting fieldwork. That's the whole point of it.

listening always,

-S ♡

This guide is educational and reflects general practice considerations and my own experience as a supervisor. It is not legal or regulatory advice, and it does not replace the BACB Handbook, your supervision contract, or direction from your responsible supervisor. Certification requirements change — verify current standards at bacb.com before making decisions about your fieldwork. Current as of [Month Year].